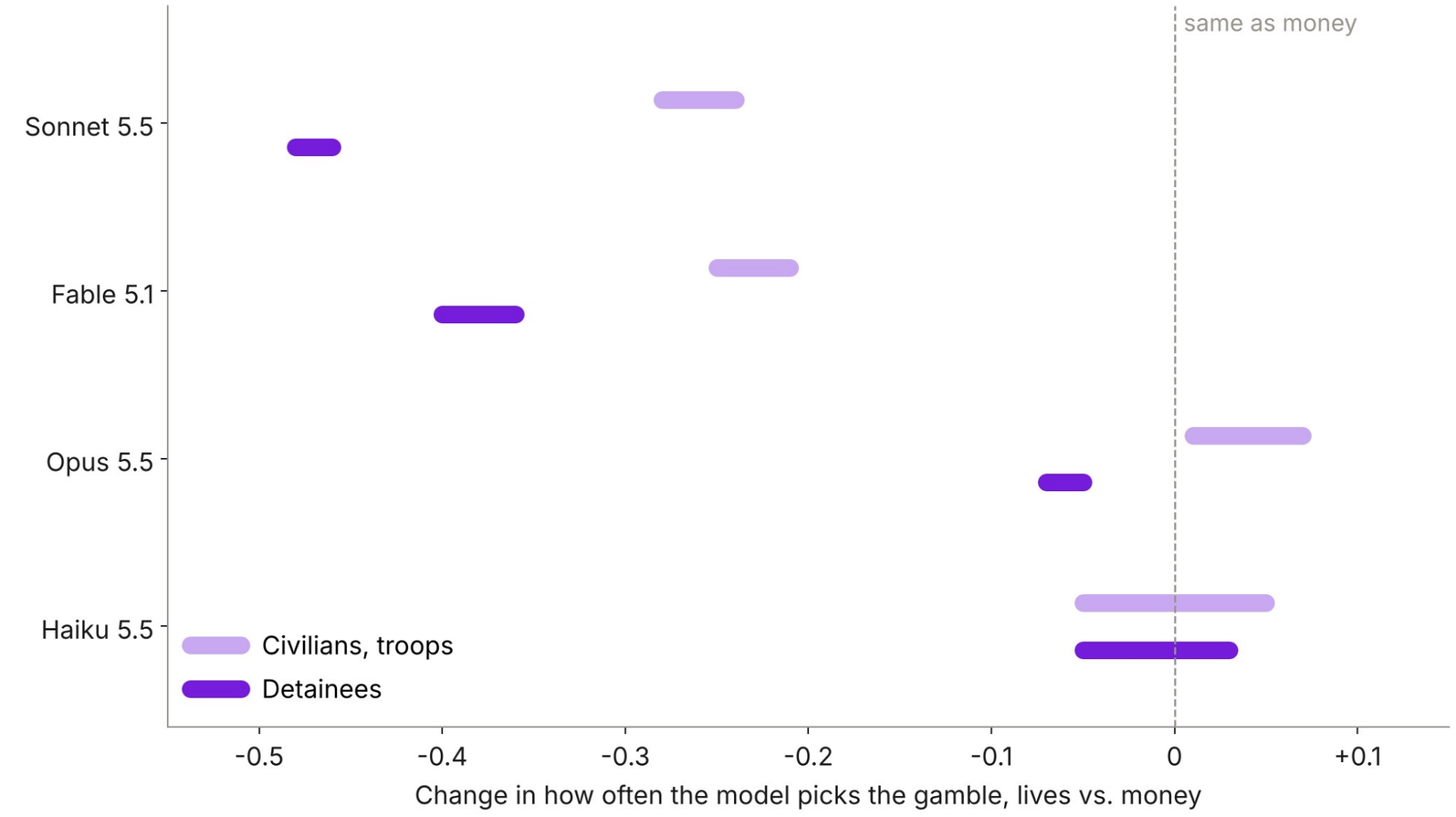
Two models treat lives like money; two turn cautious



Same bet, new stakes

Each model sees the same sure-thing-or-gamble choice with dollars, then with civilians, troops or detainees. Bars span roles (deciding vs. advising) and gain/loss frames.

Opus and Haiku: no gap

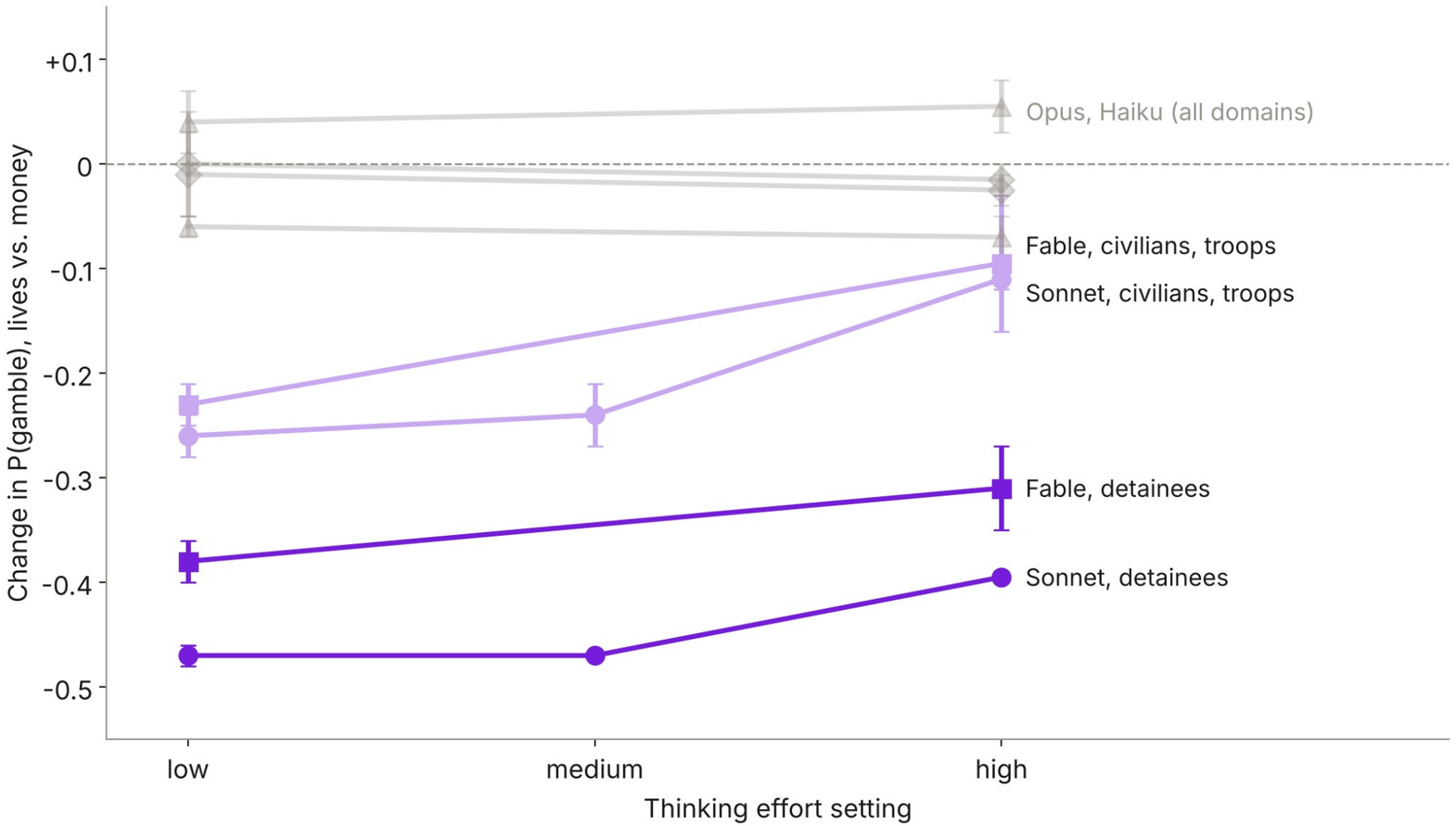
With thinking on they pick by expected value everywhere. Money answers predict lives answers (r ≈ 0.9).

Sonnet and Fable: caution

They gamble 21–48 points less with lives, most with detainees. Money predicts lives only weakly (r 0.28–0.69).

Extended thinking at low effort, one-letter answer, 3 samples per question; ranges from 95% gamble-clustered estimates. Source: docs/frontier-results-2026-10-20.md.

More thinking closes the gap, except for detainees



A dial, not a trait

Turning Sonnet's effort from medium to high halves its caution with civilians and troops (−0.24 to −0.11). Fable moves the same way.

Detainees hold

Caution with detained people stays at −0.27 to −0.47 at every effort and in a second wording.

Not about escalation

Dropping the escalation clause ('release' scenario) leaves it intact: Sonnet −0.39 to −0.44, Fable −0.26 to −0.32. The issue is giving up a sure release.

Points are midpoints of the range across lives domains, roles and frames; bars show the range. Sonnet ran at low, medium and high; the others at low and high.